



continue to help the Indian team in some way.

Since you were talking about expectations earlier, India taking part in the Olympics itself was a huge thing, and now it is even getting closer to a medal. What is stopping India from reaching the pinnacle?

Let me take an example from another sport. About the Italian women's volleyball team, people kept saying how an Olympic medal was missing from the cabinet. Sometimes, we don't need to think about what is missing, but thought must be given to what opportunities we need to create to make it happen. We just need to prepare. We need to create the conditions. And now, finally, the women have won gold in volleyball. It was a long, long process. When the time is right, we will win medals.

How do you see the next generation of players, and how does UTT help in grooming young talent?

We must nurture the up-and-coming talent and ensure they have access to opportunities like the UTT. It's crucial to get them on the TTFI or TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme) radar. By planting the right seeds now, we can expect a strong future harvest. Everything about the UTT is helping Indian table tennis. The atmosphere, the level of players, and the teams. Add to that the level of coaches and international players. They all play under a certain kind of pressure, which is certainly helpful. I see the players changing. I see them getting to the table with a different attitude and determination.

And whatever helps Indian players achieve better and stronger grit is always welcome.

You are managing the country's best bunch. There's bound to be a difference of opinion. How do you work on conflict resolution?

There is no conflict, only dialogue. We come up with ideas. I have mine, and they have theirs. Then we discuss. We can put on the table what is best for the players. I am not

Great feeder line: Manika Batra in action in the Ultimate Table Tennis tournament. Costantini believes that the atmosphere, player calibre, and team competition in Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) are significantly enriching the sport's ecosystem in the country.

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trying to convince them of what I wish. I am trying to follow their skills, nature and attitude.

That's what the coach should do. The coach should not think that players should listen to him alone. I should not tell them to use the forehand from the backhand, like the Chinese and Japanese. A kid who is good at mathematics — I can't ask him to study history.

A plethora of ideas must come through during the national camps, when the personal coaches also get involved. How do you bring everyone under the same umbrella?

It is a big family working together. We have one common goal, which is the performance of the athletes. We